THE BOX-IN-SPHERE FRACTAL ATLAS

A geometric–dynamical map to learn mathematics (with optional philosophy)

(Navigation tool: orientation, translation, and study routing; not a replacement for proofs)

Kevin T.N.

jkdkr2439@gmail.com

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Abstract

This document is a **full, expanded** version of the Box-in-Sphere Atlas, now with **worked examples** for each mapped branch. The **Box** is the region of discrete rules, finite checks, rewriting, and structural contracts. The **Sphere** is the region of continuity, models, deformation, and dynamical intuition. The **Boundary** marks tool-limits: analytic blow-ups, proof-theoretic independence, computational barriers, and representational failures. A **fractal extension** introduces a multi-scale hierarchy (discipline → field → topic → concept), so "zooming in" preserves the same navigation logic.

Scope Oath (Contract). This atlas is **not** mathematics. It is a **navigation layer** to help learners:

- locate a topic (Box / Sphere / Boundary / Outside),
- choose the right tool class (rewrite, linear, smooth, topological, stochastic),
- translate between branches (change representation),
- detect which boundary you are hitting,
- design study routes (what to learn next).

If a claim needs truth, return to formal tools: definitions, axioms, proofs, models, computations.

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1 Part I — The Representation Principle

Principle 1 (Geometry–Dynamics Representation)**.** Any topic chunk can be organized as a triple

$$(X,\ F,\ \mathcal{T}),$$

where X is a state space (objects live here), F is a constraint system (equations/inequalities/invariants), and $\mathcal{T}$ is a class of allowed transformations (rewriting, symmetries, flows, deformations, stochastic updates).

Rule of thumb 1 (Static vs. dynamic vs. stochastic vs. rewrite)**.** A topic is usually dominated by one of these *modes*:

- **Static (constraint) mode:** $F(x) = 0$ or $F(x) \leq 0$.
- **Dynamic (flow) mode:** $\dot{x} = G(x)$ or $\partial_t u = \mathcal{L}(u)$.
- **Stochastic mode:** $x_{t+1} \sim K(x_t, \cdot)$ (Markov kernel / random update).
- **Rewrite (syntactic) mode:** $s \Rightarrow s'$ (rule-based transformations).

Most fields mix modes, but learning improves when you identify the dominant one.

2 Part II — The Two Primitives in $\mathbb{R}^n$: Box and Sphere

Definition 1 (Sphere (closed ball))**.** For radius $R > 0$,

$$\mathcal{S}_n(R) := \{x \in \mathbb{R}^n :\ \|x\| \leq R\}, \qquad \partial\mathcal{S}_n(R) := \{x \in \mathbb{R}^n :\ \|x\| = R\}.$$

Sphere-reading: continuous families, smooth variation, deformation, models.

Definition 2 (Box (axis-aligned cube/box))**.** For scale $a > 0$,

$$\mathcal{B}_n(a) := \{x \in \mathbb{R}^n :\ |x_i| \leq a/2 \text{ for } i = 1, \ldots, n\}.$$

Box-reading: discrete constraints; finite rules; symbolic contracts. A box is an intersection of finitely many half-spaces (hyperplanes).

Definition 3 (Four regions (epistemic partition))**.** Assume $\mathcal{B} \subseteq \mathcal{S}$.

- **Inside the Box:** rule-first, syntactic, finite verification.
- **Between Box and Sphere:** model-first, continuous intuition, approximation.
- **Boundary:** where tools fail or change phase.
- **Outside:** not representable under the current contract (yet or in principle).

3 Part III — Four Core Operations (How the atlas "moves")

Principle 2 (The four operations)**.** The atlas workflow is generated by:

1. **Embedding / encoding:** choose where objects live (often $X \subseteq \mathbb{R}^n$).

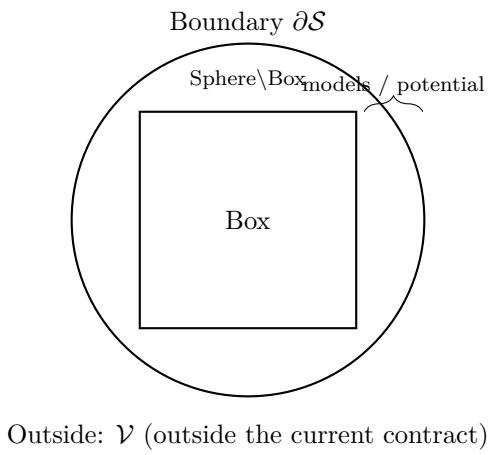

Figure 1: 2D cross-section: the Box (square) sits inside the Sphere (circle).

2. **Transformations:** specify allowed maps $x \mapsto \Phi(x)$ (the tool class).
3. **Slicing / sectioning:** intersect with a hyperplane or project to lower dimension.
4. **Dimension lifting:** add coordinates to encode parameters, hidden states, or structure.

Rule of thumb 2 (Slicing is the universal visualization move)**.** When a topic feels too abstract, slice it: high-dimensional constraints $\to$ 2D/3D sections, global behavior $\to$ local charts, systems $\to$ special cases. In the atlas: slicing is a controlled way to "enter the Box" from the Sphere.

4 Part IV — Transformation Taxonomy (All motion / deformation classes)

Transformation classes (practical taxonomy).

- **Rigid (isometries):** translation, rotation, reflection, screw motion.
- **Similarity:** rigid + uniform scaling (zoom).
- **Affine/linear:** $x \mapsto Ax + b$ (shear, anisotropic scaling, change of basis).
- **Projective:** perspective-like transforms (incidence structure focus).
- **Smooth (diffeomorphic):** bending, twisting, warping; smooth coordinate changes.
- **Flow families:** Φ_t generated by ODE/PDE (time-evolution).
- **Stochastic updates:** Markov kernels, random walks, stochastic flows.
- **Singular maps:** folds, cusps, pinches, collapses (phase transitions).
- **Topological surgery:** cut/glue, create/fill holes, split/merge components.
- **Rewrite (syntactic):** inference rules, normalization, term rewriting.
- **Meta-transforms:** change language/axioms/representation ("change the Box").

5 Part V — Boundary Types (Four kinds of "tool ceilings")

Definition 4 (Boundary types)**.** We distinguish four boundary modes:

- ∂_L (Limit/regularity): non-convergence, blow-up, non-smoothness.
- ∂_P (Proof-theoretic): independence, incompleteness, consistency constraints.
- ∂_C (Computational): undecidable, intractable, complexity barriers.
- ∂_R (Representational): encoding too weak/too costly; wrong coordinates.

Rule of thumb 3 (Boundary diagnosis)**.** When stuck, identify the boundary type first; then switch tools: $\partial_L \to$ estimates/regularization; $\partial_P \to$ change axioms or accept independence; $\partial_C \to$ approximation/heuristics/reductions; $\partial_R \to$ new representation (basis, coordinates, viewpoint).

6 Part VI — The Atlas Map M (Formal navigation rule)

Definition 5 (Atlas map M)**.** For a topic fragment T, define

$$M(T) = (Z,\ \mathcal{T},\ \partial,\ \text{mode}),$$

where $Z \in \{\text{Box}, \text{Sphere}, \text{Boundary}, \text{Outside}\}$, $\mathcal{T}$ is the dominant transformation class, ∂ is the nearest boundary type(s), and mode $\in \{\text{static}, \text{dynamic}, \text{stochastic}, \text{rewrite}\}$.

Rule of thumb 4 (Validity test for a mapping)**.** A mapping is *useful* if it predicts at least two of:

- which tools solve typical exercises,
- which errors come from mixing regions,
- which tool-switch helps when stuck.

If it predicts none, the mapping is decorative and should be revised.

7 Part VII — Global Index Table (multi-page, no cut-off)

Table 1: Global atlas index (coarse). Detailed examples appear in Part VIII.

Branch	**Region bias**	**Objects & transforms (typical)**	**Mode / boundary**
Proof theory (syntactic logic)	Box $\to$ Boundary	Formulas, proofs; inference/rewrite systems	Rewrite/static; ∂_P
Model theory (semantics)	Sphere + Box	Structures/models; satisfaction; interpretations	Static; ∂_R
Set theory / foundations	Box $\to$ Boundary	Membership; axioms; hierarchies; forcing intuition	Static; ∂_P

Continued on next page.

Branch	**Region bias**	**Objects & transforms (typical)**	**Mode / boundary**
Combinatorics / graph theory	Box	Graphs; counting; rewiring; invariants	Static; sometimes ∂_C
Discrete math (general)	Box	Finite objects; recurrences; discrete transforms	Static/dynamic; ∂_C
Linear algebra	Box	Vectors; $GL(n)$; eigen-structure; bases	Static; ∂_R (conditioning)
Abstract algebra	Box	Groups/rings/fields; homomorphisms; presentations	Static; ∂_R
Geometry (Euclidean/affine)	Sphere + Box	Points/lines/planes; isometries; affine maps	Static; rigid/affine
Projective geometry	Sphere-ish	Incidence; duality; projective transforms	Static; projective class
Topology	Sphere (soft)	Spaces; continuous deformation; invariants	Static; surgery at type-changes
Differential topology	Sphere (smooth)	Manifolds; smooth maps; transversality	Static/dynamic; ∂_L
Differential geometry	Sphere (smooth)	Metric/curvature; diffeomorphisms; connections	Static/dynamic; ∂_L
Real/complex analysis	Sphere	Limits; continuity; holomorphic maps; estimates	Dynamic intuition; ∂_L
Functional analysis	Sphere (high-dim)	Banach/Hilbert spaces; operators; spectra	Static/dynamic; ∂_L
Measure theory	Sphere + Box	σ-algebras (Box); measures (Sphere)	Static; ∂_R
Probability theory	Sphere + Box	Distributions; conditionalization; Markov kernels	Stochastic; ∂_C sometimes
Stochastic processes	Sphere	Random walks; SDEs; filtrations; semigroups	Stochastic/dynamic; ∂_L
ODE / dynamical systems	Sphere	Phase space; flows; stability; attractors	Dynamic; ∂_L
PDE / applied analysis	Sphere	Fields; evolution operators; shocks/singularities	Dynamic; ∂_L
Numerical analysis	Box + Sphere	Discretization approximating continuous models	Dynamic; ∂_R
Optimization	Sphere	Energy landscapes; constraints; gradient flows	Dynamic; ∂_R (nonconvexity)
Number theory	Box	Integers; congruences; lattices; modular maps	Static; ∂_R
Algebraic geometry	Sphere + Box	Polynomial constraints; varieties/schemes; morphisms	Static; ∂_R
Category theory	Meta	Objects/morphisms; functors; naturality	Meta-static; organizes $\mathcal{T}$
Computability	Boundary	Machines; reductions; decidability	Static/dynamic; ∂_C
Complexity	Boundary (pragmatic)	Resource-bounded computation; reductions	Static; ∂_C

8 Part VIII — Branch-by-Branch Examples (full worked mini-maps)

Rule of thumb 5 (How to read each module)**.** Each branch below includes: (1) atlas placement $M(T)$, (2) a canonical encoding (static/dynamic/stochastic/rewrite), (3) a slicing or dimension-lifting example, (4) a common region-mixing error and a tool-switch.

8.1 (1) Proof Theory (Syntactic Logic)

Proof theory as Box + rewrite dynamics

Atlas placement: $M = (\text{Box},\ \text{rewrite},\ \partial_P,\ \text{rewrite/static})$.
Canonical encoding: A proof system is a rewrite machine on strings/trees:

$$\Gamma \Rightarrow \varphi \quad \text{generated by rules (e.g. Modus Ponens).}$$

In Box-language: correctness is a finite check (proof verification).
Slice / lift example: Slicing = restrict to a fragment: propositional logic $\to$ Horn clauses; or full first-order $\to$ quantifier-free. This is a "hyperplane cut" in the space of formulas: fewer connectives, fewer rules.
Common error & tool-switch: Error: using semantic intuition (Sphere) to claim provability (Box). Switch: either (i) produce a formal derivation, or (ii) move to model theory and state it as "true in all models" instead of "provable" (Box $\leftrightarrow$ Sphere boundary awareness).

Mini example. From $\varphi \to \psi$ and φ, derive ψ (Modus Ponens). This is a pure Box move: a local rewrite step.

Boundary note (∂_P). Statements can be true in intended semantics yet independent of a chosen axiom system.

8.2 (2) Model Theory (Semantic Logic)

Model theory as Sphere + Box (structures as points in a model space)

Atlas placement: $M = (\text{Sphere+Box},\ \text{interpretations},\ \partial_R,\ \text{static})$.
Canonical encoding: A structure $\mathfrak{M}$ is a "point" in a semantic space. Truth is $\mathfrak{M} \models \varphi$. Changing interpretation is a transformation Φ on models (renaming, reduct/expansion).
Slice / lift example: Slicing = fix the language or cardinality: e.g. consider only groups of order n, or only fields of characteristic p. You cut down the semantic universe to a manageable section.
Common error & tool-switch: Error: mixing "model" as informal intuition with "model" as a formal structure. Switch: state explicitly which sense is used. If formal, provide the signature and interpretation.

Mini example. In the language of groups, $\forall x\,(x \cdot e = x)$ holds in every group model. Truth is checked in Sphere-semantic space, not by syntax alone.

8.3 (3) Set Theory / Foundations

Set theory as Box with proof boundaries

Atlas placement: $M = (\text{Box} \to \text{Boundary},\ \text{axioms \& constructions},\ \partial_P,\ \text{static})$.
Canonical encoding: Core objects are sets; core constraints are axioms (ZFC, etc.). A "construction" is a rule-driven build inside the Box.
Slice / lift example: Slicing = restrict universes: hereditarily finite sets, or rank-initial segments V_α. Dimension lifting = add a new axiom (a meta-coordinate) and observe downstream changes.
Common error & tool-switch: Error: treating independence as "false". Switch: label it ∂_P, then either (i) change axioms, or (ii) work conditionally.

Mini example. Cantor diagonal: show no bijection $\mathbb{N} \to \mathcal{P}(\mathbb{N})$. A Box proof that reveals a boundary of "size" (cardinality hierarchy).

8.4 (4) Combinatorics / Graph Theory

Combinatorics as Box with occasional computational boundaries

Atlas placement: $M = (\text{Box},\ \text{discrete transforms},\ \partial_C\ \text{sometimes},\ \text{static/dynamic})$.
Canonical encoding: Graphs are finite objects; transforms are rewires, contractions, deletions. Constraints include degrees, connectivity, forbidden subgraphs.
Slice / lift example: Slicing = fix parameters: number of vertices n, degree bound d, planarity. Dimension lifting = encode extra labels/weights to model richer problems.
Common error & tool-switch: Error: assuming a counting problem is easy because it is finite. Switch: check ∂_C (complexity): use approximations, recurrences, or probabilistic methods.

Mini example. A tree on n vertices has $n - 1$ edges (Box invariant under edge deletion constraints). If you try to count all graphs with a property, complexity can become the real boundary.

8.5 (5) Linear Algebra

Linear algebra as affine/linear transformations inside the Box

Atlas placement: $M = (\text{Box},\ GL(n)\ \text{and linear maps},\ \partial_R,\ \text{static})$.
Canonical encoding: Objects: vectors/matrices. Transformations: $x \mapsto Ax$ and change-of-basis. Constraints: $Ax = b$, rank conditions, orthogonality.
Slice / lift example: Slicing = reduce to invariant subspaces. Example slice: restrict to the span of an eigenvector. Dimension lifting = augment with a slack variable.
Common error & tool-switch: Error: confusing geometric intuition with basis-dependent coordinates. Switch: change basis (a controlled transform) until the structure becomes diagonal/block form.

Mini example (eigen-as-axis). If $Av = \lambda v$, then along the line spanned by v, the transform is a pure scaling. This is "one-axis" motion extracted by slicing to an invariant 1D subspace.

8.6 (6) Abstract Algebra (Groups/Rings/Fields)

Abstract algebra as Box: structures + homomorphisms (structure-preserving maps)

Atlas placement: $M = (\text{Box},\ \text{structure-preserving transforms},\ \partial_R,\ \text{static})$.
Canonical encoding: Constraints are algebraic laws (associativity, distributivity, etc.). Transformations are homomorphisms; invariants appear via kernels, images, quotients.
Slice / lift example: Slicing = pass to a subgroup/ideal (a section of the structure). Dimension lifting = adjoin generators/relations (presentation).
Common error & tool-switch: Error: thinking "same elements" implies "same structure". Switch: compare via homomorphisms and invariants (kernel/image/quotients).

Mini example. A group homomorphism $f : G \to H$ factors through $G/\ker f$. This is a canonical "collapse" move that stays inside Box rules (quotient construction).

8.7 (7) Euclidean/Affine Geometry

Geometry as Sphere+Box: constraints + symmetry transformations

Atlas placement: $M = (\text{Sphere+Box},\ \text{rigid/affine/projective transforms},\ \partial_R,\ \text{static})$.
Canonical encoding: Constraints are equations of lines/planes/spheres:

$$\text{plane: } n \cdot x = c, \qquad \text{sphere: } \|x - c\|^2 = R^2.$$

Transformations include isometries and affine maps.
Slice / lift example: Slicing = intersect 3D objects with planes to get circles/ellipses. Dimension lifting = add coordinates for parameters (family of circles, etc.).
Common error & tool-switch: Error: mixing coordinate artifacts with geometry. Switch: use invariants under the transform class (distance for isometries, parallelism for affine).

Mini example. Intersect a sphere with a plane: $\|x - c\|^2 = R^2$ and $n \cdot x = c_0$ gives a circle (or empty set). This is a direct "slice" operation in the atlas.

8.8 (8) Projective Geometry

Projective geometry as incidence-first (projective transforms)

Atlas placement: $M = (\text{Sphere-ish},\ \text{projective transforms},\ \partial_R,\ \text{static})$.
Canonical encoding: Objects: points/lines with incidence; transformations preserve collinearity. Coordinates can be lifted: (x, y) becomes homogeneous $[X : Y : Z]$.
Slice / lift example: Dimension lifting example: encode affine plane into projective plane by adding "points at infinity". This lift resolves parallel lines by moving them to a boundary component.
Common error & tool-switch: Error: importing Euclidean metric intuition (distance/angle) into projective claims. Switch: focus on cross-ratio and incidence invariants.

Mini example. Two parallel affine lines meet at a point at infinity in projective completion. This is literally a boundary-handling tool: move a Euclidean edge case into a projective point.

8.9 (9) Topology

Topology as Sphere (soft): continuous deformation + invariants

Atlas placement: $M = (\text{Sphere (soft)},\ \text{homeomorphism/homotopy},\ \text{type-change boundary},\ \text{static})$.
Canonical encoding: Objects: spaces; transformations: continuous deformations. Constraints are invariants (connectedness, fundamental group, homology).
Slice / lift example: Slicing = local chart view (zoom into neighborhoods). Dimension lifting = attach a parameter to track deformation over time (a homotopy).
Common error & tool-switch: Error: using geometric measurements (Box-ish) to decide topological equivalence. Switch: use topological invariants (e.g. number of holes).

Mini example. A coffee mug and a torus are equivalent (one handle). That is a Sphere-soft deformation, not a rigid motion.

8.10 (10) Differential Topology

Differential topology as Sphere (smooth): singularities are ∂_L

Atlas placement: $M = (\text{Sphere (smooth)},\ \text{smooth maps},\ \partial_L,\ \text{static/dynamic})$.
Canonical encoding: Objects: smooth manifolds; transforms: diffeomorphisms, smooth homotopies. Boundary events: critical points, non-transversality, singular maps.
Slice / lift example: Slicing = transverse intersection (generic slicing to produce clean submanifolds). Dimension lifting = add parameters to create a family and apply transversality.
Common error & tool-switch: Error: assuming every map can be made nice without conditions. Switch: impose genericity/transversality assumptions (a controlled tool upgrade).

Mini example. A generic height function on a surface has isolated critical points. When critical points merge, you hit a boundary-like event (phase change in the Morse picture).

8.11 (11) Differential Geometry (Riemannian)

Differential geometry as curvature-driven deformation

Atlas placement: $M = (\text{Sphere (smooth)},\ \text{curvature \& connections},\ \partial_L,\ \text{static/dynamic})$.
Canonical encoding: Objects: (M, g) (manifold + metric). Transformations: diffeomorphisms, gauge-like changes. Constraints: curvature equations; geodesic equations (ODE on manifolds).
Slice / lift example: Slicing = choose a coordinate chart or a geodesic surface. Dimension lifting = encode moving frames/connection coefficients as extra coordinates.
Common error & tool-switch: Error: treating curvature as a coordinate artifact. Switch: compute coordinate-free invariants (sectional curvature, Ricci scalar).

Mini example. Geodesics solve an ODE; curvature controls divergence/convergence of nearby geodesics. Blow-ups or degenerations are ∂_L events.

8.12 (12) Real/Complex Analysis

Analysis as Sphere: limits, continuity, estimates

Atlas placement: $M = (\text{Sphere},\ \text{limits/flows},\ \partial_L,\ \text{static/dynamic})$.
Canonical encoding: Canonical static claim: limit/continuity. Canonical dynamic claim: evolution under differential operators (flow intuition).
Slice / lift example: Slicing = restrict to a sequence (1D path) or to a compact subset. Dimension lifting = introduce parameters to build families (e.g. ε-regularization).
Common error & tool-switch: Error: assuming "it looks smooth" implies differentiability or uniform convergence. Switch: add estimates (norm bounds), or move to weaker convergence notions.

Mini example. The derivative is a boundary operation:

$$f'(x) = \lim_{h \to 0} \frac{f(x+h) - f(x)}{h}.$$

If the limit fails, you are at ∂_L.

8.13 (13) Functional Analysis

Functional analysis as high-dimensional Sphere: operators and spectra

Atlas placement: $M = (\text{Sphere (high-dim)},\ \text{linear operators},\ \partial_L,\ \text{static/dynamic})$.
Canonical encoding: Objects: Banach/Hilbert spaces; transforms: bounded operators, adjoints, semigroups. Constraints: norms, compactness, spectral properties.
Slice / lift example: Slicing = restrict to invariant subspaces or to finite-dimensional approximations. Dimension lifting = represent an operator by kernel/graph in product spaces.
Common error & tool-switch: Error: importing finite-dimensional intuition (all bounded sets are compact). Switch: identify the boundary: compactness fails; use weak topology or compact operators.

Mini example. In infinite dimensions, the unit ball need not be compact. That failure is a classic ∂_L-flavored boundary of naive geometric intuition.

8.14 (14) Measure Theory / Integration

Measure theory as Sphere+Box: σ-algebras (Box) + measures (Sphere)

Atlas placement: $M = (\text{Sphere+Box},\ \text{pushforward/conditioning},\ \partial_R,\ \text{static})$.
Canonical encoding: Box part: σ-algebra rules (closure properties). Sphere part: measure values; integration as a continuous aggregation tool.
Slice / lift example: Slicing = restrict to measurable subsets, or to simple functions approximating a general function. Dimension lifting = add product spaces to encode joint distributions (Fubini viewpoint).
Common error & tool-switch: Error: assuming every subset is measurable. Switch: remember representational boundaries: measurability is a contract.

Mini example. Approximate a measurable function by simple functions; then define the integral as a limit. This is a controlled Sphere move built on a Box contract.

8.15 (15) Probability Theory

Probability as stochastic dynamics on a measure space

Atlas placement: $M = (\text{Sphere+Box},\ \text{Markov kernels},\ \partial_C \text{ sometimes},\ \text{stochastic})$.
Canonical encoding: A Markov chain is a stochastic update:

$$X_{t+1} \sim K(X_t, \cdot).$$

Distributions evolve by pushforward (a linear operator on measures).
Slice / lift example: Slicing = marginalize (project) from a joint distribution to one coordinate. Dimension lifting = build joint spaces to represent dependence.
Common error & tool-switch: Error: mixing "almost sure" with "sure" statements. Switch: specify the mode of truth (a.s., in probability, in distribution).

Mini example. A two-state Markov chain has a 2×2 transition matrix P. Stationary distribution solves $\pi P = \pi$ (static constraint inside a stochastic model).

8.16 (16) Stochastic Processes (SDE intuition)

Stochastic processes as Sphere: random paths + boundary explosions

Atlas placement: $M = (\text{Sphere},\ \text{stochastic flows},\ \partial_L,\ \text{stochastic/dynamic})$.
Canonical encoding: A stochastic differential equation (formal) looks like:

$$dX_t = b(X_t)\,dt + \sigma(X_t)\,dW_t,$$

where W_t is Brownian motion (random driving).
Slice / lift example: Slicing = look at finite-dimensional distributions at times $t_1, \ldots, t_k$. Dimension lifting = include time as a coordinate; include noise state if modeling discretely.
Common error & tool-switch: Error: treating dW_t like an ordinary derivative. Switch: use the correct calculus (Itô/Stratonovich) and state the interpretation.

Mini example. Brownian paths are continuous but nowhere classically differentiable. That is a boundary phenomenon relative to smooth calculus (∂_L).

8.17 (17) ODE / Dynamical Systems

ODE as flow: the archetypal "Sphere dynamics" module

Atlas placement: $M = (\text{Sphere},\ \Phi_t \text{ flow},\ \partial_L,\ \text{dynamic})$.
Canonical encoding: Dynamics:

$$\dot{x} = F(x), \quad x(0) = x_0,$$

generates a flow $\Phi_t(x_0)$. Stability and attractors are geometric objects in phase space.
Slice / lift example: Slicing = restrict to invariant sets (fixed points, limit cycles). Dimension lifting = convert higher-order ODEs into first-order systems.
Common error & tool-switch: Error: inferring global behavior from a local linearization without conditions. Switch: identify assumptions (Lipschitz, invariance), or use Lyapunov functions.

Mini example. $\dot{x} = -kx$ has solution $x(t) = x_0 e^{-kt}$. Everything flows toward 0: a clear attractor picture.

8.18 (18) PDE / Applied Analysis

PDE as field evolution: dynamics plus singular boundaries

Atlas placement: $M = (\text{Sphere},\ \text{operator flows},\ \partial_L,\ \text{dynamic})$.
Canonical encoding: Canonical example (heat equation):

$$\partial_t u = \Delta u.$$

The solution is a smoothing flow. Other PDEs (shocks) create singularities.
Slice / lift example: Slicing = Fourier modes (project to frequency space). Dimension lifting = convert PDE to an infinite-dimensional ODE in a function space.
Common error & tool-switch: Error: assuming smoothness persists for all time. Switch: check boundary type: blow-up and shock formation are ∂_L events.

Mini example. Heat flow reduces roughness over time (Sphere smoothing). Conservation laws can form shocks (boundary singularities).

8.19 (19) Numerical Analysis

Numerical analysis as Box approximating Sphere

Atlas placement: $M = (\text{Box+Sphere},\ \text{discretization transforms},\ \partial_R,\ \text{dynamic})$.
Canonical encoding: Discretization maps continuous dynamics into step updates:

$$x_{n+1} = x_n + hF(x_n) \quad \text{(Euler method)}.$$

Stability and conditioning are representational boundaries.
Slice / lift example: Slicing = choose a small step size or restrict to linear test equations. Dimension lifting = introduce error states and study error propagation dynamics.
Common error & tool-switch: Error: treating a convergent method as always stable. Switch: analyze stability region (a geometric object in the complex plane).

Mini example. For $\dot{x} = -kx$, Euler gives $x_{n+1} = (1 - hk)x_n$. Stability requires $|1 - hk| < 1$, a clean Box inequality controlling Sphere behavior.

8.20 (20) Optimization / Variational Methods

Optimization as an energy landscape with gradient flow intuition

Atlas placement: $M = (\text{Sphere},\ \text{gradient/Hamiltonian flows},\ \partial_R,\ \text{dynamic})$.
Canonical encoding: A standard model is gradient descent:

$$\dot{x} = -\nabla E(x) \quad \text{or} \quad x_{k+1} = x_k - \eta \nabla E(x_k).$$

Constraints can be encoded by penalties or Lagrange multipliers.
Slice / lift example: Slicing = fix a level set $E(x) = c$ (contour slice). Dimension lifting = add multipliers to enforce constraints.
Common error & tool-switch: Error: assuming convex intuition in a nonconvex landscape. Switch: detect boundary ∂_R: change representation, relax, or accept local minima.

Mini example. Quadratic $E(x) = \frac{1}{2}x^\top Qx$ yields linear dynamics $\dot{x} = -Qx$, linking optimization directly to linear algebra and ODE flow.

8.21 (21) Number Theory

Number theory as Box: lattices, congruences, modular transforms

Atlas placement: $M = (\text{Box},\ \text{modular maps},\ \partial_R,\ \text{static})$.
Canonical encoding: Objects live on integer lattices; constraints are congruences:

$$a \equiv b \pmod{m}.$$

Transformations include modular inverses, group structure of units, and lattice reductions.
Slice / lift example: Slicing = fix a modulus m (a finite quotient slice). Dimension lifting = embed integers into $\mathbb{R}$ or for analytic tools (analytic number theory).
Common error & tool-switch: Error: trying to solve an arithmetic problem only by continuous intuition. Switch: return to discrete invariants (gcd, residue classes), or lift dimension deliberately.

Mini example. Solve $ax \equiv 1 \pmod{m}$ iff $\gcd(a, m) = 1$. This is a pure Box invariant controlling solvability.

8.22 (22) Algebraic Geometry

Algebraic geometry as polynomial constraints + morphisms (Box+Sphere)

Atlas placement: $M = (\text{Sphere+Box},\ \text{polynomial maps/morphisms},\ \partial_R,\ \text{static})$.
Canonical encoding: Varieties are constraint sets:

$$V(f_1, \ldots, f_k) = \{x : \ f_i(x) = 0\}.$$

Morphisms are structure-preserving maps between such sets.
Slice / lift example: Slicing = intersect with a hyperplane (classical "hyperplane section"). Dimension lifting = add a homogenizing coordinate (projective closure).
Common error & tool-switch: Error: treating solutions as a mere point set and ignoring structure. Switch: track morphisms and invariants (dimension, singularities, coordinate rings).

Mini example. Circle as $x^2 + y^2 - 1 = 0$. Slice with $y = 0$ gives two points $(\pm 1, 0)$. Singularities (where Jacobian rank drops) are boundary-like events.

8.23 (23) Category Theory (Meta-language)

Category theory as "maps of maps": a meta-tool for $\mathcal{T}$

Atlas placement: $M = (\text{Meta},\ \text{functors/natural transforms},\ \partial_R,\ \text{static-meta})$.
Canonical encoding: A category packages **objects** and **morphisms**. A functor translates one "Box" into another while preserving composition.
Slice / lift example: Slicing = focus on a subcategory (restricted objects/morphisms). Dimension lifting = add structure (enrichment, higher categories) when the current encoding is too weak.
Common error & tool-switch: Error: mistaking category theory for a single branch "inside" the atlas. Switch: treat it as a language that organizes transformations across many branches.

Mini example. Forgetful functor $U : \mathbf{Grp} \to \mathbf{Set}$ maps a group to its underlying set. This is a representational projection: you lose structure on purpose.

8.24 (24) Computability Theory

Computability as the computational boundary ∂_C

Atlas placement: $M = (\text{Boundary},\ \text{reductions},\ \partial_C,\ \text{static/dynamic})$.
Canonical encoding: Objects: programs/machines; transforms: reductions $A \leq_m B$. The central constraint is decidability: does an algorithm exist for all inputs?
Slice / lift example: Slicing = restrict input domain (finite length, special classes). Dimension lifting = add an oracle (a meta-coordinate) to study relative computability.
Common error & tool-switch: Error: believing "we just need a smarter algorithm" when the problem is undecidable. Switch: prove undecidability by reduction; then change the goal (semi-decision, approximation).

Mini example. Halting problem: no algorithm decides halting for all programs. This is an explicit boundary ∂_C.

8.25 (25) Complexity Theory

Complexity as pragmatic boundary: resource limits

Atlas placement: $M = (\text{Boundary (pragmatic)},\ \text{reductions},\ \partial_C,\ \text{static})$.
Canonical encoding: Central objects: languages/problems; transforms: polynomial-time reductions. Constraints: time/space bounds; classes like P, NP.
Slice / lift example: Slicing = parameterize the problem (fixed-parameter tractability). Dimension lifting = add approximation ratio as a new coordinate to replace exactness.
Common error & tool-switch: Error: equating "hard in practice" with "hard in principle". Switch: state the model (worst-case, average-case, parameterized) and pick the right boundary framing.

Mini example. SAT is NP-complete. A practical tool-switch is: exact $\to$ approximation or heuristics, or restrict to 2-SAT (a slice).

9 Part IX — Fractal Extension (Multi-scale atlas)

Definition 6 (Fractal Box–Sphere hierarchy (learning view))**.** A level n unit is a sphere containing a box. The box has 8 vertices; each vertex spawns a child sphere (level $n-1$). This recursive construction encodes *specialization*:

$$\text{discipline} \to \text{field} \to \text{topic} \to \text{concept}.$$

Practical truncation rule (to avoid explosion). Use a fixed depth k:

$$0 : \text{discipline}, \quad 1 : \text{field}, \quad 2 : \text{topic}, \quad 3 : \text{concept}, \quad 4 : \text{exercise type}.$$

Do not expand further unless designing a syllabus.

Rule of thumb 6 (Why 8 children?)**.** The "8 vertices" can be used as 8 standardized tags when you zoom in: *object*, *transform*, *invariant*, *constraint*, *mode*, *slice*, *boundary*, *tool-switch*. Each concept node gets these 8 fields (a consistent micro-atlas).

10 Part X — Learning Toolkit (cards + drills)

Card 1 — Quick mapping checklist

1. Box or Sphere? (rules vs models/continuity)
2. Object, transform, invariant, or procedure?
3. Dominant mode: static / dynamic / stochastic / rewrite?
4. What slicing makes it visible?
5. Which boundary is near: $\partial_L, \partial_P, \partial_C, \partial_R$?
6. What tool-switch would you try next?

Drill set (one page, reusable)

For each concept in a chapter, write:

$$M(T) = (Z, \mathcal{T}, \partial, \text{mode}),$$

and give one line each for: *canonical encoding*, *slice*, *common error*, *tool-switch*.

Rule of thumb 7 (Designing a study route)**.** A robust default route for many learners:

Box rules → linear transforms → limits/flows → topological invariants → boundaries (P/C/R/L).

Customize by moving earlier into the Sphere if motivation needs models first.

11 Conclusion

Closing summary. This expanded atlas provides:

- a unified language $(X, F, \mathcal{T})$ for describing topics,
- Box/Sphere/Boundary/Outside as a cognitive partition,
- a full transformation taxonomy (motion/deformation classes),
- four boundary types $\partial_L, \partial_P, \partial_C, \partial_R$,
- worked mini-maps for major branches,
- a fractal extension for multi-scale learning and syllabus design.

A Appendix — Minimal glossary

Keyword	**Atlas reading**
State space X	Where objects live (often $\mathbb{R}^n$, a manifold, or a structured space).
Constraint F	Equations/inequalities/invariants defining admissible objects.
Transform class $\mathcal{T}$	Allowed moves: rewrite, linear, smooth, topological, stochastic, etc.
Slice/section	Reduce complexity by intersection or projection.
∂_L	Limit/regularity boundary (blow-up, non-smoothness, non-convergence).
∂_P	Proof boundary (independence, incompleteness).
∂_C	Computational boundary (undecidable, intractable).
∂_R	Representation boundary (wrong or costly encoding).